

Overview

This area of study comprises a study in depth of Hinduism as a lived religion in the United Kingdom and throughout the world.

There are two sections: Beliefs and Teachings; Practices.

Students will be expected to study Hinduism within the context of the wider British society, the religious traditions of which are, in the main, Christian.

Students should compare and contrast two areas of belief and practice within Christianity and Hinduism:

- Beliefs about the afterlife and their significance (1.5)*
- The practice and significance of worship (2.4)*.

Students should recognise that Hinduism is one of the many religious traditions in Great Britain, which include Buddhism, Islam, Judaism and Sikhism. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content. Students should also recognise that within Hinduism there may be more than one perspective in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed. Common and divergent views within Hinduism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout, including reference to Shaivism and Vaishnavism.

The significance and importance of the various beliefs and practices to Hindus today should be explored throughout the two sections.

Students should have an understanding of:

1.1	The nature of Brahman: the nature of Brahman as spirit, ultimate reality or absolute truth; how the characteristics of Brahman are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Katha Upanishad 2.2.6–8.
1.2	The nature and importance of understanding Brahman as Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman: how Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman are shown in Hindu scripture, for example Nirguna (Taittiriya Upanishad 2.7.1–2) and Saguna (Rig Veda 1.154.1–2); the nature and importance of Vaikuntha (spiritual worlds); divergent ways in which belief in each may be expressed in the life of Hindus today.
1.3	Three aspects of the divine: Brahman, Antaryami and Bhagavan; the nature and significance of the divine as Brahman (everywhere and non-personal), Antaryami (within the heart) and Bhagavan (beyond, as a personal loving God); how the three aspects are shown in Hindu scriptures, including Mundaka Upanishad 2.1; why belief in the three aspects of the divine are important in Hindu life and for religious pluralism today.
1.4	Manifestations of the Divine: the nature and importance of how the deities are shown in Hindu scriptures; avatars and murti; the nature and role of male deities: divergent understandings of the importance of Vishnu (including Rig Veda 1.22) and Shiva; the nature and role of the female force, Shakti, including Parvati and Lakshmi.
1.5*	The nature of the individual and life within Hinduism: the nature and importance of the atman (eternal self), karma, the cycle of samsara, moksha; divergent Hindu understandings of the nature of the individual and life, including interpretations of Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 4.4; why beliefs about the atman, karma, samsara and moksha are important for Hindus today.
1.6	The purpose of human life for Hindus: the nature and significance of the four aims of life (Purusharthas) – dharma, artha, kama and moksha; the nature and significance of anatana dharma (eternal law), including Bhagavad Gita 3.35; the nature and significance of varnashrama dharma (duties according to materialistic situation in life).
1.7	Hindu responses to suffering, knowledge and ignorance: Hindu teachings about suffering, knowledge and ignorance, such as ahimsa, respect, empathy, mind/sense control, humility, and love, including Mahabharata 5.39; divergent Hindu understandings as to why there is suffering, knowledge and ignorance for Hindus today.
1.8	Hindu cosmology: the nature of the Hindu cosmology as shown in Hindu scriptures, including Rig Veda 10.129; the nature and importance of the cycle of four ages (yugas), including descriptions of the Kali Yuga in the Mahabharata, many worlds and their diverse inhabitants; the nature and divergent understandings of the importance of the concepts of prakriti (matter/nature), tri-guna (three qualities) and maya (illusion).

Students should have an understanding of:

2.1	The nature and purpose of Hindu yoga: the nature and purpose of different forms of yoga: karma yoga (action), jnana yoga (knowledge), astanga/raja yoga (meditation) and bhakti yoga (devotion); examples of when each form of yoga might be used, how and why; the importance of having different types of yoga; reference to Bhagavad Gita 6.44–47.
2.2	Focuses of worship and representations of the divine: the nature, purpose and importance of different ways of worshipping, including worshipping one god (personal or non-personal) or many deities, gurus and holy places (land, hills, rivers and sacred plants and animals); the scriptural basis for the different focuses of worship and representations of the divine in worship, including interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 6.20–31.
2.3	The importance of Hindu places of worship: the nature, features of, use, and purpose of worship in different places, including in the temple, in the home, outside, shrines and festival celebration and in the space of the heart, with reference to interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 9.13–27; the benefits for Hindus of having different places to worship in.
2.4*	The nature and purpose of prayer in the temple and the home: the nature, features of use and purpose of the different forms of worship, including meditation, puja, havan, darshan, arti, bhajan, kirtan and japa, with reference to interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 6.44–47; divergent understandings of the benefits for Hindus of having different forms of worship.
2.5	Hindu sacred festivals: the nature, history, purpose and significance of Hindu sacred festivals; the origins and meaning of specific festivals, including Diwali, Holi, Navratri Dussehra, Ram Navami, Ratha-yatra, Janmashtami, and Raksha Bandhan, including interpretations of Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 1.3.28.
2.6	Hindu pilgrimage: the nature, history and purpose of Hindu pilgrimages; the significance of the places Hindus go on pilgrimage; divergent understandings of why pilgrimage may, or may not be, important for Hindus today; the nature, features, history and importance of pilgrimage to the Ganges, including interpretations of Rig Veda 10.75, Vrindavana and Varanasi.
2.7	Hindu environmental projects: divergent understandings of the nature, purpose and significance of environmental care for Hindus; the importance of care for rivers and sacred places for Hindus; how Hindus care for the environment, examples of what they do and why, including reference to cow protection and including interpretations of Rig Veda 10.87.16–19.
2.8	Hindu charity work: the nature and purpose of charity for Hindus; Hindu teachings about charity; the work of one named Hindu charity working to promote wellbeing, social inclusion and women's rights, what it does and why, including interpretations of Bhagavad Gita 3.10–12.